The Odyssey

Annotated model · "The Lotus Eaters" (from Book 9)

Homer, translated by Robert Fitzgerald · textbook page 721 · Grade 9, Unit 2, Lesson 3: Challenge Accepted!

Learning targets

9.RL.1.A I can explain a theme of the text and how its characters, setting, and plot develop that theme.

Lesson target I will annotate for character traits and major events, and show how character traits and setting drive the plot.

EQ How do the challenges of life affect a person?

Reading the annotations

Theme a line that raises a topic that develops a theme 9.RL.1.A · red notes

Character · Setting · Plot a detail that builds the theme 9.RL.1.A · red notes

Vocabulary a word to define 9.RV.1.A · blue notes

Blue notes define words. Red notes connect a detail to a theme: the numbered top line names the topic, character, setting, or plot detail, and the line under it explains how that detail builds the theme. Arrows point to the exact words.

Topic vs. theme. A topic names a subject (*temptation*). A theme carries a message or lesson about it (*giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most*). Each theme note names a topic; its number shows which theme that topic develops. The numbered themes are listed at the top of the first passage page.

The lesson's student codes. Students highlight in pink where Odysseus acts as a hero or leader, circle major events, and star what they clarify. In this model the theme-4 *Character* notes are the hero/leader moments and the *Plot* notes are the major events.

Themes

1. Giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most.
2. Comfort and pleasure can make you forget your goals.
3. Danger does not always look dangerous.
4. Life's challenges test a leader, who must make hard choices to keep the group on course.

from

The Odyssey

An Epic Poem by **Homer**

Translated by **Robert Fitzgerald**

The Lotus Eaters (from Book 9)

Odysseus is telling King Alcinous the story of his journey home from Troy. After the raid on the Cicones, where 72 of his men died, his ships set sail again for Ithaca.

"I might have made it safely home, that time, but as I came round Malea[1] the current took me out to sea, and from the north a fresh gale drove me on, past Cythera.[2] Nine days I drifted on the teeming sea before dangerous high winds. Upon the tenth we came to the coastline of the Lotus Eaters, who live upon that flower. We landed there to take on water.

1. **Malea** a cape at the southern tip of Greece.
2. **Cythera** an island off that cape.

4. Setting: a storm at sea
Plot: wind and current push them off course. Nature is the first challenge.

Vocab: teeming = swarming, full of life

3. Setting: a calm island
After the storm it feels safe: the calm before the conflict.

2. Topic: the goal of home
He is almost home. Watch what pulls the men away from it.

Vocab: gale = a very strong wind

4. Character: a patient leader
Nine days adrift: wise to ride it out, or should he fight for home?

4. Character: a caring leader
He stops for water and a meal so the crew can recover.

All ships' companies mustered alongside for the mid-day meal. Then I sent out two picked men and a runner to learn what race of men that land sustained. They fell in, soon enough, with Lotus Eaters, who showed no will to do us harm, only offering the sweet Lotus to our friends— but those who ate this honeyed plant, the Lotus, never cared to report, not to return: they longed to stay forever, browsing on that native bloom, forgetful of their homeland. I drove them, all three wailing, to the ships, tied them down under their rowing benches, and called the rest: 'All hands aboard; come, clear the beach and no one taste the Lotus, or you lose your hope of home.' Filing in to their places by the rowlocks my oarsmen dipped their long oars in the surf, and we moved out again on our sea faring."

4. Character: a careful leader
He sends scouts before risking everyone. 72 men died at the Cicones.

1. Topic: temptation
Today: like drugs. Offered in a friendly way, they feel "sweet" at first, then you stop caring about your goals.

2. Topic: forgetting home
Pleasure makes them want to stay forever. Their goal is gone.

4. Character: he protects the crew
Everyone off the beach before anyone else is tempted.

4. Plot: back on course
The leader gets them moving again. Challenge passed, for now.

3. Topic: hidden danger
No weapons, no attack. The threat is temptation, which is harder to see.

1. Plot: the scouts eat the Lotus
They never report back. Giving in costs them their mission.

4. Character: a decisive leader
He drags the wailing men back and ties them down: unpopular, but it saves them.

1. Topic: the cost of temptation
He says the theme out loud: give in and you lose your hope of home.

Vocab: rowlocks = holders for the oars

Teacher notes

How the themes develop · discussion key · model response

How the themes develop

Beginning (lines 1–12). The goal is stated: *"safely home."* The setting supplies the first challenge, a storm that blows the ships off course for nine days, then brings them to a calm island. Odysseus is patient, caring, and careful: he waters and feeds the crew and scouts before risking everyone. Themes 4, 3

Middle (lines 13–19). The danger looks harmless: the Lotus Eaters show *"no will to do us harm."* The *"sweet," "honeyed"* plant tempts the scouts, who never return and become *"forgetful of their homeland."* Themes 1, 2, 3

End (lines 19–27). Odysseus drives the wailing men to the ships, ties them down, orders everyone aboard, and states the lesson: taste the Lotus and *"you lose your hope of home."* His hard choice gets them back on course. Themes 1, 4

Discussion key (slide notes)

Slide 20, I Do (lines 1–4). A storm throws Odysseus off his route home: a major event, because it takes him off course.

Slide 21, We Do (lines 4–6). Nine days adrift: accept either side with a reason. Smart not to fight a sea he can't beat, or he should have steered for home.

Slide 21, We Do (lines 6–10). Reaching the island is a major event; stopping for water and food lets the crew recover.

Slide 21, We Do (lines 10–17). The scouts eat the Lotus and never report back. Some will say this shows the men didn't respect him.

Slide 22, partners (lines 18–27, 7 min). He ties the crying men under the benches, forbids the Lotus, and gets the ships moving; still, some men no longer wanted to go home.

Slide 23, exit discussion. The storm keeps him from home and brings him to the island; the island's Lotus makes men stop wanting to leave, which forces Odysseus to act.

Model response

In "The Lotus Eaters," Homer develops the theme that giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most. The setting drives the plot: a storm pushes the ships off course to an island where the people offer the *"sweet"* Lotus. Because the Lotus Eaters show *"no will to do us harm,"* the danger is easy to miss. The scouts who eat it become *"forgetful of their homeland,"* showing how pleasure can erase a goal. Odysseus's response completes the theme: he drags the men *"all three wailing"* to the ships and warns that anyone who tastes the Lotus will *"lose your hope of home."*

Watch for

Topic, not theme: push "temptation" to a full statement. **"The Lotus Eaters are villains":** they are not hostile; the danger is inside the men. **Modern connection (line 14):** the Lotus is offered kindly and tastes "sweet," like drugs passed around by friends; ask what the men lose (their goal, their way home) and what students could lose. **Who is telling this?** Odysseus narrates to King Alcinous, so he may make himself look like a better leader than he was.